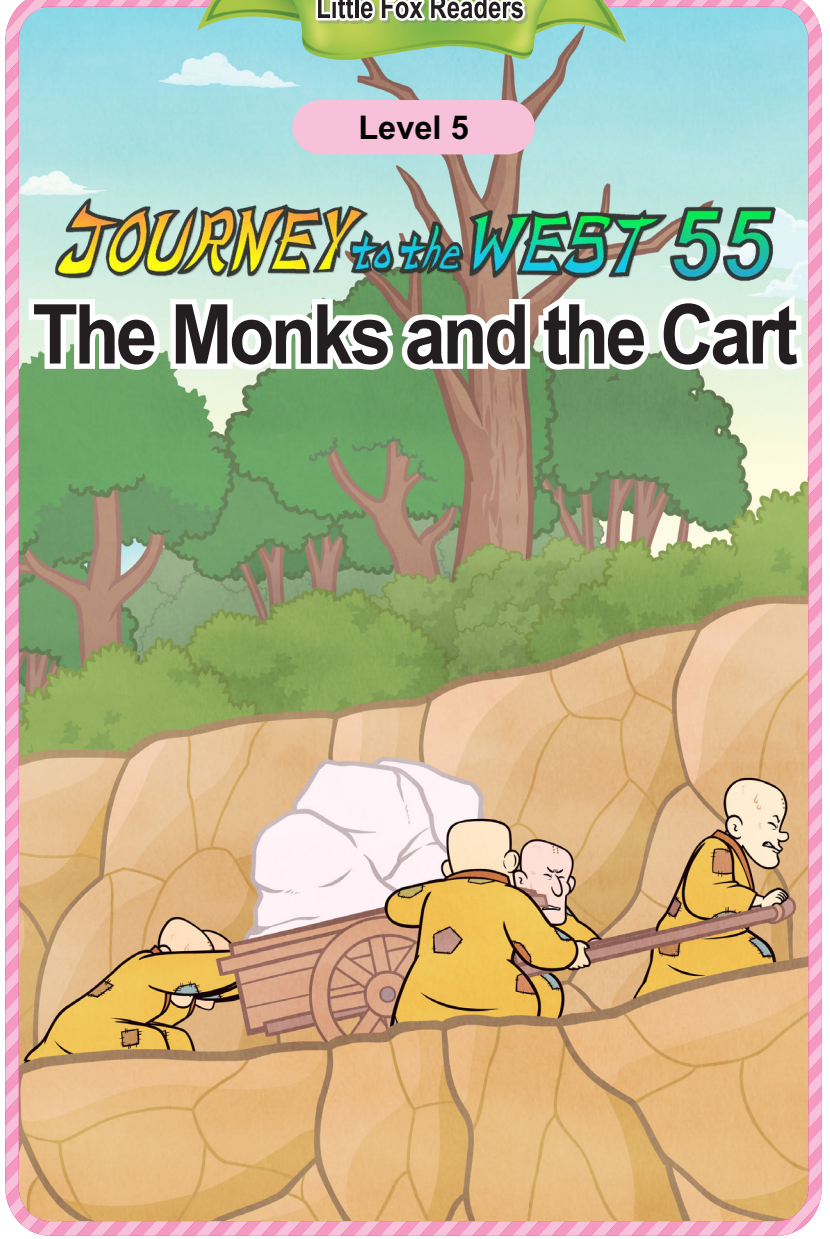
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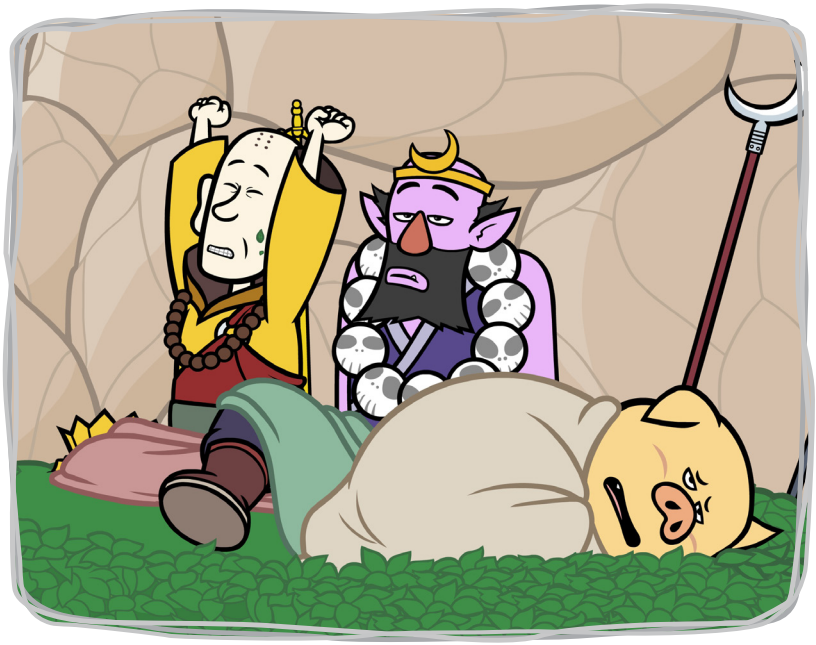
Level 5

JOURNEY to the WEST 55

The Monks and the Cart



Little Fox



Everybody, wake up!” called Wukong.

The travelers had camped for a night in the woods. The Tang Monk woke up and stretched. Wujing opened his eyes and yawned.

Bajie moaned, “It’s too early. Let me sleep just a few more hours.”

“Bajie, don’t be lazy,” said the Tang Monk. “It’s time to get up. Please start



making breakfast."

The pig got to his feet. "All we do is work," he said. "Cook food . . . carry bags . . . walk, walk, walk!"

"We're on a noble mission," said Wujing. "Because of our difficult journey, the Tang Empire will have the True Scriptures. You should be happy to do all this work."

After a quick breakfast, the group started

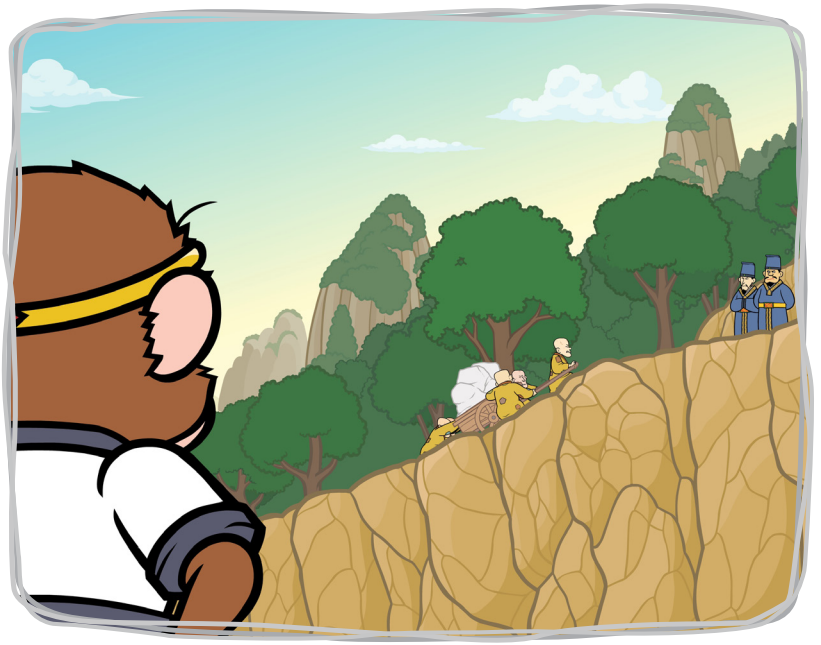


walking. They went through a valley and over some hills. Later that afternoon they heard yelling.

"It sounds like some people are in trouble," said the Tang Monk.

Wujing nodded. "Yes. I wonder what's going on."

"You all wait here," said Wukong. "I'll go and investigate."



The monkey leaped into the air and looked around. He saw a group of Buddhist monks pushing a cart up a steep hill. The cart was loaded with big stones. The monks looked miserable. Their robes were dirty and ripped.

Two Daoist priests stood nearby. They were dressed in fine clothes.

"Work faster!" yelled one of the priests.

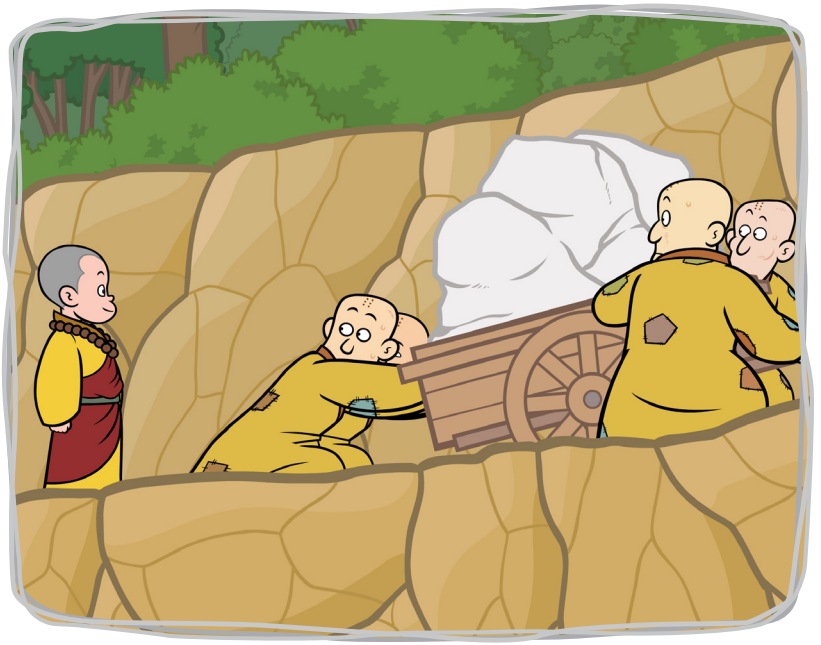


The Buddhists looked frightened. They struggled to move the cart faster.

"Why are those monks pushing that cart?" thought Wukong. "And why are they scared of the Daoists?"

The monkey waited for the Daoists to leave. Then he made himself look like a Buddhist monk.

"Hello," said Wukong, walking toward



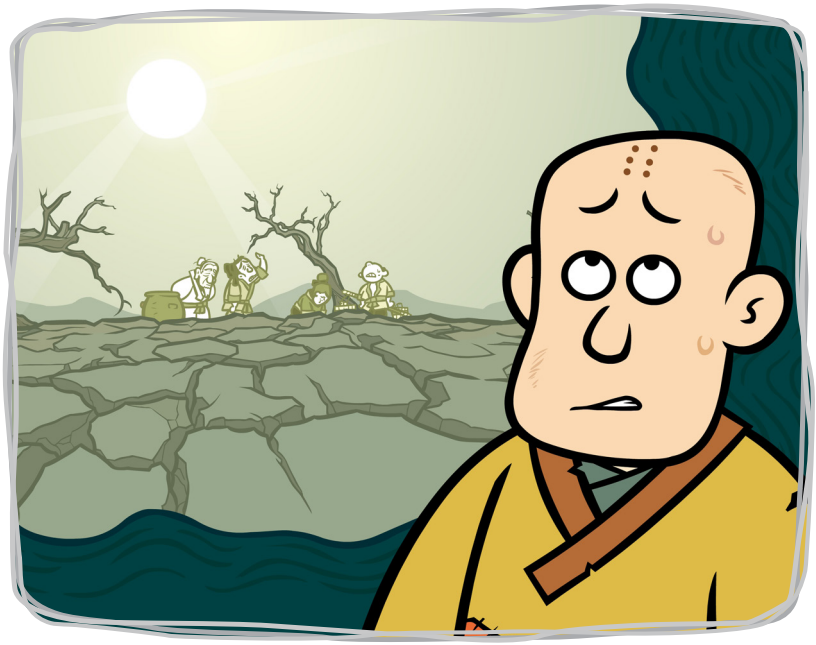
the group of monks. “Why are you pushing this cart?”

The monks stopped pushing the cart and turned toward Wukong. They looked surprised.

“You must be new here,” one monk said. “You should leave before you’re discovered.”

“Why?” asked Wukong.

“Daoists are in charge here,” said another



monk.

Wukong shrugged. “People from different religions can still get along.”

“Not in this kingdom,” said the first monk. “Buddhists are treated horribly here. The Daoists make us do hard work.”

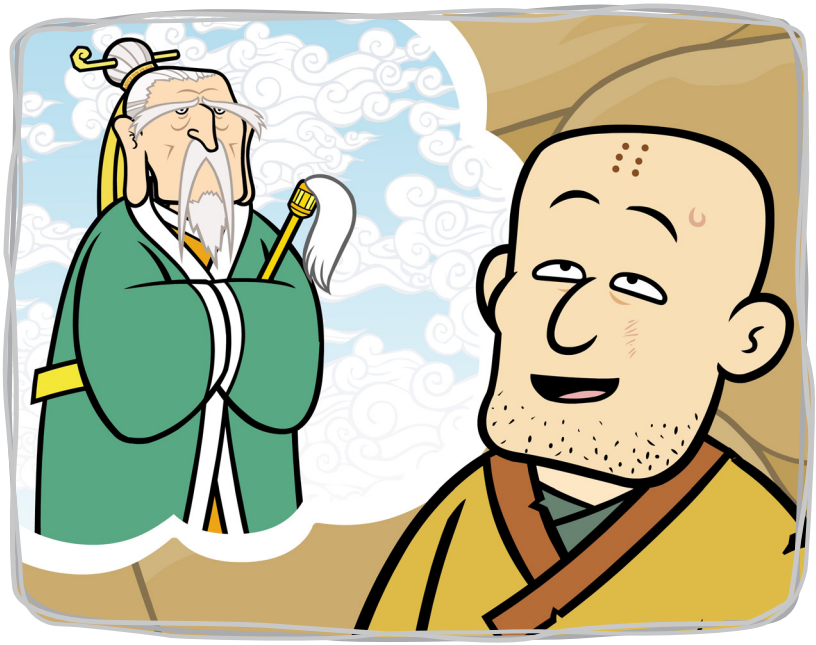
“Why do the Daoists treat you so badly?” asked Wukong.

“Years ago this kingdom had a drought,”



said the monk. “Crops died and people starved. Buddhist monks prayed to Buddha for rain. But no rain came.”

“One day a powerful Daoist arrived,” said the other monk. “He’s called the Tiger Immortal. He recited prayers, and right away rain fell. Since then Daoists have been in charge. They destroyed all the Buddhist monasteries and statues.”



"That's terrible," said Wukong. "Those Daoists can't get away with this."

"The Daoists won't treat us this way forever," said a third monk. "The spirit of the planet Venus visited us in a dream one night. He said that one day someone would come along to save us."

"Oh really?" Wukong raised an eyebrow. "Who is going to save you?"

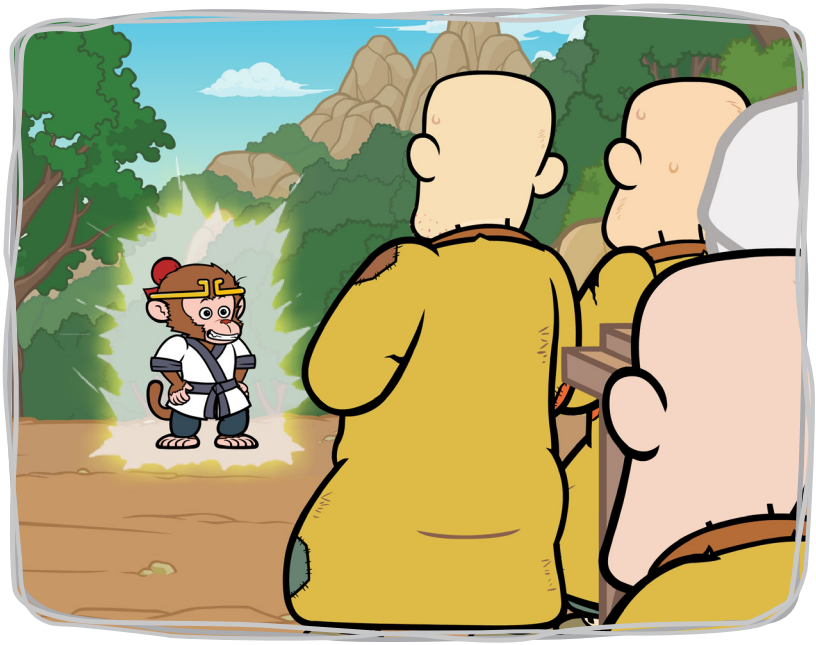


"A fierce monkey spirit," said the monk. "His name is Sun Wukong. He is so powerful that Heaven's entire army couldn't defeat him!"

Wukong smiled. "I've heard of Sun Wukong. And it's true that he's very powerful. Did Venus tell you what he looks like?"

"Oh yes," said the monk.

"So you'll recognize him if you see him?"



asked Wukong, trying not to laugh.

"Certainly," said the monk. "Why do you ask?"

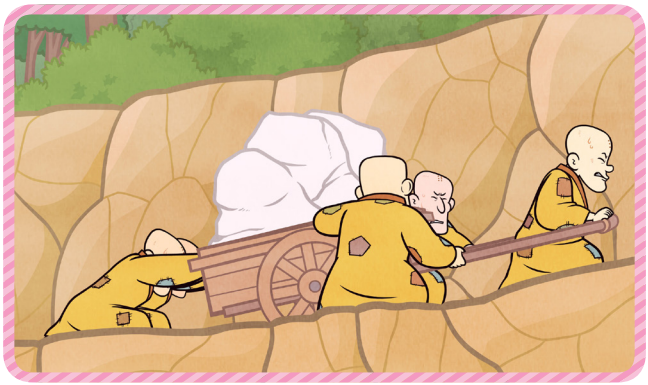
Light sparkled around Wukong. A moment later he was a monkey again.

"Sun Wukong!" cried the monks. They all fell to their knees and bowed.

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